



Cover story **Maritime Security**

Drowned in INDECISION

The Centre's inaction, despite repeated warnings from the Gujarat Government, has left the state's coastline poorly secured. The inertia could cost the nation dear.

| By Uday Mahurkar |

Long before the Merchant Vessel *Kuber* was hijacked by Mumbai-bound terrorists off the Gujarat coast, the writing was on the wall. It's just that the Government and the security establishment refused to read it. In the past four years, the Gujarat Government sent numerous reminders to the Centre about a comprehensive coastal security plan it had drawn up to secure its 1,600 km-long coastline and each time the Home Ministry stonewalled them. The last rejection came on November 21, five days before the Mumbai attack. Gujarat Minister of State for Home Amit Shah says, "We tried to convince the Centre that half-baked measures won't do since we are right next to Pakistan. But the Centre has shown a marked lack of security vision." Narendra Modi had taken up the matter with the Centre late last year at the chief minister's conference on internal security but ran into yet another brick wall.

The proposal was first mooted in 2003 when the BJP-led NDA government was in power. A five-year plan costing Rs 371 crore, the proposal involved setting up 51 police stations along the state's coastline, 70 outposts, 90 watch towers, 32 speedboats and three interceptor boats and giving identity cards to fishermen in the coastal villages. The Government had also proposed setting up a Fishermen Watch Group to keep an eye on the activities of the fishermen (see box). Five years later, the state Government still awaits their approval.

Meanwhile, for the first time in 37 years since

